



Crop Planning In The Market Garden

5 STEPS TO YOUR PLANNING

1. Establish your objectives and financial goals
2. Establish your game plan
3. Establish your operating calendars
4. Establish the map of the season
5. Order seeds, equipment and material

STEP1- SET YOUR OBJECTIVES AND FINANCIAL GOALS

- State, determine or reaffirm your mission statement
- Think about and write what goals you want to achieve next season
- Determine what is your financial objective, mainly sales objectives

DETERMINE WHAT IS YOUR FINANCIAL OBJECTIVES, MAINLY SALES OBJECTIVES:

- A well-run market garden with the most of the workload accomplished by the growers can expect to have margins from 35% to 65%.
- Sales objectives need to be aligned with your markets, your experience the size of your operation and your seasonality.
- Sales target should be realistic; not conservative, nor pie in the sky
- Can you add another profit stream for the same number of clients? Example: eggs

SALES OBJECTIVES, AN EXAMPLE:

- A 2.5 acre (1 hectare) market garden with 180 permabeds (100'-30M) long
- 1 greenhouse 42'X110' (13m X33m) and 3 cold houses 30'X100' (9m X30m)
- 3 employees, 1 seasoned grower
- In production 8 months/per year, selling 35 weeks/year
- Good sales outlets and good quality (following the steps of this masterclass!)

\$160,000 X 50% (profit margins) = \$80,000 revenue

- Is that enough for your household income?
- Do you need to work another job?
- Can you improve your cost of production?
- Can you add another profit stream for the same number of clients? Example eggs

160 000K/35 weeks = 4 500K/week

- Can you handle the workload?
- Can your market support such weekly sales?
- Is that seasonality realistic?
- 4 500K/years= weeks at double that? Can you handle 9000K? Can your delivery truck support it?

STEP 2–ESTABLISH YOUR GAME PLAN

- Determine your sales outlets
- Determine what you are growing for whom and in what quantity.
- You're on your own with your game plan

GAME PLAN: EXAMPLE

- Selling to chefs on Wednesday
- Selling at Farmers' Market on Saturday
- Have a small C.S.A. pick-up on Thursday night
- Could be anything.... Grocery stores, buyers coop, fat CSA, etc...

WHAT CROP ARE YOU GROWING?

- Are you growing everything? Really?
- Inexperienced growers should perhaps limit themselves to 30 crops
- Focus on high value (yields/space/time) crop
- Focus on crops that mechanize farm can hardly handle (ex. mesclun, roots with their tops on, greens, etc)

NOW, DETERMINE HOW MUCH YOU NEED OF EACH

- Estimate how much you're going to sell of each product/sales outlets.
- Calculate your production in terms of yield/beds
- The bed is your unit of measure

AND THEN, FROM WHEN TO WHEN YOU ARE GROWING IT

- Chefs like reliability and constancy

- The first one a market is the king
- C.S.A. member will appreciate balance shares
- I could go on and on....

IT COULD LOOK LIKE THIS...

CARROTS

Harvest the equivalent of 2 beds per week from April to December. Estimated 250 bunch/week

- **16 beds** of storage carrots for our winter carrots. Best date for this is around August 5th
- **4 beds** early seedlings will be planted in tomato house early January and should be should 8 weeks later.
- **4 beds** will go into the cold house mid-February 4 beds
- **4 more** beds will be planted mid-mars in caterpillar tunnels
- **2 beds** planted per week from April 15 (first outdoor seedling) to August 8 (triple the last planting)

Notes:

No rainbow carrots

We almost always sell all of our carrots—might plan to grow 3 beds a week if we have the space.

MESCLUN

Harvest from 8 beds of Salanova + 2 beds of frisée from April to December. Estimated 200 lbs/week

- 10 beds every 3 week with multiple harvest.
- Transplanted from mars to 1 to October 25
- First indoor planting is XXXX
- Last indoor planting is XXXX

AND SO ON AND SO FORTH...

CONSIDERATION ABOUT YOUR GAME PLAN

- Make sure you're on target with your sales objectives
- Make sure you have the space in the garden
- Crop planning 2.0 would be to measure if you have enough man power....

STEP 3–ESTABLISH YOUR OPERATING CALENDARS

- Pre-planning is winning strategy
- Systemize all your complexity into simple procedures to follow
- IMPOSSIBLE to remember everything, so don't try!
- Dynamic calendars are your best friends

STEP 4–ESTABLISH THE MAP OF YOUR SEASON

- Make sure everything fits
- Allows to manage secession in a timely manner
- Think about where you put crops with regard to one another. We've grouped ours.
- Think about irrigation, insect nets, row covers, etc. EVERYTHING that will help you streamline the management of your crop

STEP 5–ORDER SEEDS, EQUIPMENT AND MATERIAL

- Choose cultivars
- Order seeds for the whole season
- Start with fresh seeds if possible
- Shop around \$\$\$